

Early-Stage GTM, Sales and Growth

Founder and operator notes, ordered from choosing a problem to building a repeatable growth machine.

The notes are intentionally practical. Use the early sections before reaching for channels; use the later sections once customers are repeating the same problem, buying for similar reasons and staying.

1. Start with the problem

Before tactics, decide whether the product solves an urgent problem and whether a buyer can understand it quickly.

The two brutal reasons a product is not growing

Jeff Weinstein

A useful reset when the team is proposing more campaigns, channels or growth hires.

Either:

- It does not solve a burning pain.
- The product experience is not good enough that people tell their friends.

Growth tactics are secondary. Put every proposed initiative into one of those two buckets.

Describe the verb, not the category

A buyer should understand the action and outcome without translating your category language.

"We're building a cloud platform for AI" produces glazed eyes. "We containerize your code and run it on GPUs so you don't have to manage the infrastructure yourself" produces understanding.

Delete the word "platform"

One founder changed "AI-native intelligence layer for field operations" to "We cut pump inspection reports from 42 minutes to 6." Conversion doubled. Buyers are not allergic to vision; they are allergic to homework.

Install the product for the first customer

At the earliest stage, remove every avoidable step between interest and use.

When a prospect says, "Sure, I'll try it," the average founder sends a link. The higher-agency move is: "Give me your laptop," and complete the setup on the spot.

- If the prospect will not adopt the tool, become the product yourself. Viaweb built the stores by hand.
- Early adopters are rarely price-sensitive. Pricing too low can signal weakness.
- Price off the value gap, not cost. Every discount trains the customer to devalue the offer.
- A fast "no" is almost as valuable as a "yes" because it frees bandwidth.
- At the beginning, hunt only the top 1% of innovators. The rest of the market is noise.

A founder's advantages are passion and domain expertise. Technique can be outsourced or imitated; those two cannot.

2. Win the first customers

Sell before you automate. Run the loop by hand until the same customer, problem and language begin to recur.

A 0-to-1 GTM loop for a technical founder

Ansh / Mireye

For the first month, use one win condition: maximise qualified calls booked. Everything else is secondary.

Daily loop: thesis → prospecting → messaging → outreach → follow-ups → retro → repeat.

- **Week 0:** write a testable thesis. It will be wrong.
- **Week 1:** find the first 50 prospects by hand. Do not buy a list. Write short, human, founder-voice emails with no links and no hard ask for a call.
- **Week 2:** stay fully manual. Collect the exact words customers use for the problem. That vocabulary becomes the positioning.
- **Week 3:** wait for the signal before automating: the same problem described in the same way, similar company size and roughly a 10% response rate.
- **Week 4:** turn every repeated step into a Claude skill. The stack used was Exa for prospects, EmailHunter, Granola for notes, Superhuman for sending, a CSV as the CRM, a diligence document before every demo and a learnings document after every call.

The highest-leverage tactic was the second email after someone opened the first. Follow-ups that lead with proof booked more calls than cold first touches. Rewrite anything that smells like AI. Pattern recognition and positioning are both engineered by running the loop by hand first.

The Ramp missing-link follow-up

A simple way to create a natural second touch without inventing a new reason to email.

In the first email, refer to a meeting link but "forget" to include it. Then send a short correction: apologise, add the link and move on. The follow-up feels personal and gives the sender a clean reason to re-enter the inbox.

3. Earn the right to scale

Retention, fit and a working sales loop come before channel proliferation.

0 to 1,000+ paid customers in 20 weeks

Finn Mallery

A sequence for turning early demand into a product people keep using.

1. Grow retention before growth. Do not scale a leaky bucket. Hit 90% weekly retention first.
2. Ignore everyone who is not your customer.
3. Manual is faster than perfect. The first 50 users each received a personal onboarding call.
4. Validate before you build. Put a credit-card gate in on day two.
5. An ugly product beats no product. Ship a barely working version quickly.
6. Customers write the roadmap. Still spend three hours a day on user calls.
7. Fire bad-fit customers early. Ten customers who love you beat a thousand who kind of like you.
8. Ship every week without exception.
9. Stay small longer than feels comfortable. Headcount is not progress.
10. Know burn and runway. Track whether you are "default alive" every week.
11. Expect things to break. The game is how quickly you put the fires out.
12. Honest conflict with a cofounder is the cheapest insurance.

What “growth” can actually mean

Anson Lin

Useful when deciding what role to hire or what workstream you are really missing.

“Growth” can mean paid and performance, content and social, community and IRL, lifecycle and retention, events and field, partnerships and ecosystem, influencers and UGC, product-led growth, referral programmes, brand or guerrilla marketing. The only shared meaning is: make the numbers go up.

4. Add channels in order

Do not run five half-working channels. Win one, keep it running, then add the next.

\$0 to \$3.9m ARR, channel by channel

Dylan Txa / Gojiberry

The company did not discover one magic channel. It added new channels only after the previous one worked.

Stage	Primary motion
\$0-6k MRR	Pure outbound: cold email and LinkedIn, using the company’s own early product.
\$6-25k MRR	Educational Reddit posts. More than 10 million organic views flooded the trial funnel at near-zero cost.
\$25-75k MRR	Founder-led LinkedIn, YouTube and motion content, plus free internal “blueprints.”
\$75-150k MRR	Partnerships, X, B2B influencers, sponsored newsletters, lifetime affiliates and YC.
\$150k+ MRR	Paid acquisition on Meta and Google, plus the first serious hires.

None of the earlier channels were abandoned. They continued while new ones were added. Beat one channel until it clearly works, then add the next. Running five channels in parallel is usually wasted force.

LinkedIn GTM for technology companies

Logan Gott

A founder-led distribution system for B2B companies whose buyers already spend time on LinkedIn.

- The founder posts daily. Company pages reach roughly 1.6% of followers.
- Every post is built around the problem you solve, not the team, features or fundraising announcement.
- Map the funnel before posting. Every impression needs a next step that can lead to a call.
- Pull semi-viral AI takes from X that already resonate with your ICP.
- Mix in case studies. Trust comes before purchase.
- Pin one PDF carousel on the ICP’s biggest problem to the Featured section.
- The founder comments on 10-20 prospect posts every day before doing outbound.

A viral launch playbook for X

Okara

A launch is a coordinated distribution event, not a single post.

- **Product:** Solve a real problem, show value in the first 30 seconds and make the aha moment and signup frictionless.
- **Messaging:** Use a one-page press release as the single source of truth.

- **Video:** Keep it under 60 seconds: problem → solution → clear call to action.
- **Thread:** Study successful hooks, write 20, choose the scroll-stopper and attach the video.
- **Supporters:** Pre-commit more than 50 friends, users and investors. Send calendar invites and organise first-hour engagement.
- **Influencers:** Send a short brief and example quote-tweets.
- **Launch day:** Launch when the ICP is active, message supporters and influencers, reply to everything and track conversions.
- **After:** Follow up, turn feedback into product changes, boost if needed and share milestones.
- **Loop:** Build → launch → feedback → improve → launch again.

The short-video volume playbook

A paid distribution tactic used by some fast-growing consumer apps; useful where reach matters more than a tightly controlled brand voice.

- Run 20-30 short videos a day across dozens of creator accounts.
- Use a paid creator marketplace that charges only on verified views, usually around \$0.12-\$1 CPM.
- Specify the winning format once. The network multiplies it.

Surface area becomes the dominant variable. The trade-off is straightforward: reach scales quickly, but quality and brand risk scale with it.

Generative search and indexing hygiene

Gagan Ghotra / Manoj Ahirwar

The basic search and crawl work still matters; most "AI SEO" shortcuts do not replace it.

Google's generative search features still use the same core ranking and quality systems. They rely on retrieval-augmented generation, grounding and query fan-out, all of which pull from the core Search index.

- Create useful, non-commodity content for the audience.
- Keep the technical structure clear.
- Submit the sitemap to Bing Webmaster Tools and IndexNow.
- Check robots.txt. Many sites inherit a blanket Disallow: / from a template and accidentally block AI crawlers.

The primary source is Google's own developer guide. Most "AI SEO" tricks are unnecessary.

5. Build the operating system

Once the motion works, qualification, ownership and measurement matter more than adding activity.

The full GTM workstream

Finn Mallery

A map of the jobs that eventually need an owner. It is not a checklist to complete before selling.

Market

Market definition · Ideal customer profile · Personas · Jobs to be done · TAM, SAM and SOM

Positioning

Positioning · Category design · Messaging frameworks · Proof and case studies

Offer

Pricing research · Packaging · Value metric · Commercial model

Channels and motion

Inbound · Outbound · Partnerships · Self-serve · Sales-led · Product-led growth

Demand and conversion

Content engine · Launch tiers · Demand generation · Pipeline · Lead scoring · Conversion and closing

After the sale

Onboarding · Customer success · Advocacy · Expansion revenue

Measurement and scale

CAC and LTV · Attribution · Win-loss analysis · Continuous optimisation · New segments · New geographies · RevOps · Repeatable playbooks

A practical GTM tool stack

Chris Balestras

A lightweight stack for founders who still run much of the motion themselves.

- Superhuman - email
- Claude - general chatbot
- Wispr Flow - voice-to-text
- Dust or Gumloop - prompt-based agents for mundane task automation
- Kondo - LinkedIn
- Granola - notes
- Clay - enrichment and GTM workflows

Notably absent: the heavily marketed AI SDR tools.

A few rules worth keeping

Isaac

General principles that apply across channels and company stages.

- Follow whales. If demand is exploding in a category, swimming behind the wake makes winning much easier.
- A rising tide lifts all boats. Competitors advertising the category often help you.
- Tell your own story. Nobody else will do it for you.
- Referrals are the strongest marketing channel. Most experiences are mediocre, so someone singing your praises usually means you genuinely outperformed.
- Momentum matters. If you lose it, fight to get it back. People can sense it and want to join the winning side.

6. Scale by doing less

At higher revenue, better qualification and clearer ownership can matter more than adding calls or headcount.

The first \$1m month with a three-person GTM team

Chris Pisarski / Crustdata

Thirty days before the milestone, the team was told to cancel more calls and disqualify far more aggressively.

Hours of Fathom recordings showed how much time and context switching was being wasted on deals that would never close.

Three deliberate moves

- Build an internal qualification tool from every closed-won deal, grouped by ICP. Score new prospects and surface lookalikes. Focus on ICPs already proven to close.
- Disqualify in the first two minutes: pain scored from 1 to 10, signing timeline and pricing reaction. The harder the attempt to disqualify, the harder good prospects sell themselves.

- When someone is not a fit, route them to self-serve or the better alternative tool. The relationship dividend is large.

The three roles

- Inbound: content across every surface, an internal distribution platform pushing to hundreds of accounts daily, a creator and partner network, SEO, AEO and viral tools.
- Outbound: fully in-house and value-based; Claude-powered; obsessive about domain health, sequencing, ICP, list building and custom tooling.
- Experiments: a single owner whose only mandate is to launch high-upside bets that can produce non-linear results.